compromise or concession. In China's view, the swap was a compromise/concession even if India did not see it that way. India did contemplate a creative compromise/concession as well: in 1959, given the strategic importance of the Aksai Chin road for Beijing, Nehru proposed privately to his colleagues that China could be allowed to use it. Opposition within his own team caused him to water down the proposal and to offer the road for civilian use only.[122] The problem, particularly in India, is public opinion, which is more prone than the leadership to associate compromise and concession with appeasement and weakness.

A third answer to why India and China are mired in disagreement is that both sides have what psychologists call 'cognitive dissonance'. More often than not, information from the other side is assimilated to pre-existing and unshakeable views. The other side's actions are regarded cynically: its statements and actions are seen as Trojan horses intended to deceive. Only an unbending stance can therefore bring security. Cognitive dissonance is not peculiar to India and China. Individuals and entire political systems are prone to discounting discrepant information, and they try to overcome it by what one might call 'triangulation' – by getting a variety of views and constant cross-checking. The problem in India and China was that in Nehru and Mao they had two enormous and forceful personalities who tended to be fed information and ideas that reinforced rather than challenged their views. Nehru and Mao are long gone, but neither system is notable for academic and policy expertise on the other country, expertise that might provide alternative views. With Modi and Xi at the helm, India and China are once again governed by rather magisterial personalities not known for reaching out to those with other viewpoints.

A final answer to why India and China have been unable to agree on anything related to their perimeters with each other is that neither political leadership, at least since Nehru and Mao, has had the ability and courage to handle nationalist domestic opinion. Lack of trust, a zero-sum view of security, and a discounting of uncomfortable evidence could be overcome by a leadership which makes the case that cooperation is possible, that security is not always necessarily zero-sum, and that prevailing views must